CINEMA ▼

SILENCE IN HIS VEINS

FILMMAKER **GURVINDER SINGH**, WHO JUST WON THE PUNJAB GAURAV AWARD FOR HIS CONTRIBUTION TO CINEMA, TALKS ABOUT HIS LATEST, *REHMAT*, STARRING NASEERUDDIN SHAH AND MITA VASHISHT

Dense fog peeps in through the huge living room window. The setting feels straight out of his film *Chauthi Koot* (The Fourth Direction), where a submarine gloom clings to the characters. Like those in the movie, his voice carries a peculiar quiet—the kind that can lead to an explosion at the next bend. There are more pauses than conversation, more suggestions than revelations, arriving in tiny bursts, even as National Award-winning filmmaker Gurvinder Singh—his films, *Anhe Ghore Da Daan* (Alms for a Blind Horse) and *Chauthi Koot* premiered at the Venice and Cannes film festivals, respectively—looks content with the bread he has just baked.

In other news, his latest Punjabi feature *Rehmat* (Compassion), starring Naseeruddin Shah and Mita Vashisht among others, is set to release in a few months. Based on four short stories by Punjabi writer Ajeet Cour, the film came to Singh when Cour's painter daughter, Arpana Caur, approached him and offered to fund the project. "All my films have been based on literary works, but after this one, my own stories will come alive," says the FTII graduate, whose documentary, *Trolley Times* (2023), captured the farmers' protests on Delhi's borders.

REHMAT IS BASED ON FOUR SHORT STORIES BY PUNJABI WRITER AJEET COUR. IT'S FUNDED BY HER DAUGHTER, THE PAINTER ARPANA COUR

While Singh, who also paints, has mostly worked with non-actors in all his films, for this one he felt only Shah could do justice to the role. "Naseer didn't talk about the script, budget or fee. He agreed to do a Punjabi film, having seen my previous work," says the director of *Adh Chanani Raat* (Crescent Night) from 2022. The new film will also see the debut of 51-year-old Jaswant Zafar, a major Punjabi poet.

For someone who lived in Bir (Kangra district, Himachal Pradesh), and now resides on the lazy outskirts of Chandigarh, staying away from Mumbai has been a conscious choice. "I don't want to network or make commercials. Also, who wants to make too many films?" asks Singh, who feels the government has completely withdrawn support from independent cinema, while OTT platforms don't pay enough to cover even production costs.

It is time for soup and bread. Remembering an earlier exchange, he smiles, "We have become too used to movies that are just about the unfolding of dialogue. In real life, silence conveys much more. Sometimes, it screams too." ■

—Sukant Deepak



PAUSE AND EFFECT Filmmaker Gurvinder Singh

SUKANT DEEPAK